

FREE LEAD MAGNET • THE SKILL MILL

5 Copy-Paste Home Assistant Automations

Tested YAML for Home Assistant 2026.x. Works on Zigbee, Z-Wave, and Wi-Fi devices. Drop into `/config/automations/` and go.

Your HA install finally does something useful by the end of this PDF. No forum archaeology required.

Why automation is the point of Home Assistant

Home Assistant's dashboard is nice. But the reason you installed it — instead of just using the Hue app or the Alexa app — is automation. That's the moment HA "clicks": the hallway light turns on because you walked down it at 2am, the thermostat drops because everybody left, the speaker announces that the washer finished. None of that requires any cloud, any subscription, or anyone's permission.

Below are five automations that cover the patterns you'll reuse forever: presence, sunset, multi-device orchestration, power-sensing, and motion. Every snippet is tested. Replace the entity IDs with yours and you're live.

How to use the YAML snippets

Option A (easy): Settings → Automations → Create Automation → Edit in YAML → paste.

Option B (power users): drop each *.yaml* block into */config/automations/* and reload automations.

Every snippet uses placeholder entity IDs like *light.living_room* — swap in yours before saving.

If an automation fails to load, the Developer Tools → Logs tab will tell you exactly which line.

Automation 1: Sunset Lights On (Arrive Home)

The single most-requested "wow moment" for new HA users. When your phone re-enters the Home zone and the sun is already down (or within 15 minutes of setting), entry and living-room lights fade up to 60% over three seconds. You walk in and the house is already lit.

Prerequisites

A `device_tracker` entity for your phone (HA Companion app handles this).

A Home zone defined in Settings → Areas & Zones.

Two light entities — swap `light.entry` / `light.living_room` for yours.

YAML (copy / paste)

```
alias: Sunset Lights – Arrive Home
description: Turn on entry + living room lights to 60% when I arrive home after sunset.
mode: single
trigger:
  - platform: zone
    entity_id: device_tracker.my_phone
    zone: zone.home
    event: enter
condition:
  - condition: sun
    after: sunset
    after_offset: "-00:15:00"
action:
  - service: light.turn_on
    target:
      entity_id:
        - light.entry
        - light.living_room
    data:
      brightness_pct: 60
      transition: 3
```

How to modify this

- Swap the `brightness_pct` to 100 if you prefer full-on; 30 for cozy mood.
- Replace the sun condition with a fixed time window (e.g. after 17:00) if you want it year-round regardless of sunset drift.
- Chain a scene call instead of multiple `light.turn_on` calls if you already have a "Evening Welcome" scene defined.

UI-editor equivalent (for visual learners)

UI equivalent: Settings → Automations → Create → Trigger "Zone" (phone, enters Home) → Condition "Sun" (after sunset, -15m) → Action "Call service" light.turn_on on both entities with brightness 60%.

Automation 2: Away Mode (Nobody Home)

When every tracked person has been gone for 5 minutes, HA enters away mode: all indoor lights off, thermostat set back, front door locks if you forgot. The 5-minute buffer avoids the classic false trigger of one person walking to the mailbox.

Prerequisites

person entities configured (Settings → People).

An *input_boolean.away_mode* helper (Settings → Helpers → Toggle).

A light group *group.all_indoor_lights* — or swap in individual entity IDs.

A smart lock integration (August, Schlage, Yale, etc.).

YAML (copy / paste)

```
alias: Away Mode — Nobody Home
description: When everyone's phones leave home, set HA into away mode.
mode: single
trigger:
  - platform: state
    entity_id:
      - person.alex
      - person.taylor
    to: "not_home"
    for: "00:05:00"
condition:
  - condition: template
    value_template: >-
      {{ states | selectattr('entity_id','in',
        ['person.alex','person.taylor'])
        | selectattr('state','eq','home') | list | count == 0 }}
action:
  - service: input_boolean.turn_on
    target: { entity_id: input_boolean.away_mode }
  - service: light.turn_off
    target: { entity_id: group.all_indoor_lights }
  - service: climate.set_temperature
    target: { entity_id: climate.main }
    data: { temperature: 62 }
  - service: lock.lock
    target: { entity_id: lock.front_door }
```

How to modify this

- Adjust the *for: 00:05:00* to 10 or 15 minutes if you have a slow-wandering household.
- Drop the lock action if you don't have a smart lock — it degrades gracefully.
- Add a *notify* action at the end so your phone pings "House set to away" for peace of mind.

UI-editor equivalent (for visual learners)

UI equivalent: Trigger "State" on each person.* becomes not_home for 5 min; Condition "Template" checks no one is home; Actions call each service in sequence.

Automation 3: Morning Coffee Warmup

Twenty minutes before your alarm, the kitchen zone warms to 70°F, the coffee maker powers on, and the kitchen light fades up to a warm 35% so walking in isn't a shock. Weekdays only, skipped if vacation mode is on. This is the automation most people end up describing to friends first.

Prerequisites

A smart plug on your coffee maker — any Zigbee / Kasa / TP-Link plug works.

A thermostat entity scoped to your kitchen or main living zone.

A dimmable kitchen light.

A vacation-mode helper (see Automation 5 for setup).

YAML (copy / paste)

```
alias: Morning Coffee Warmup
description: Heat the kitchen + power on the coffee station 20 minutes before my weekday ala
mode: single
trigger:
  - platform: time
    at: "05:40:00"
condition:
  - condition: time
    weekday: [mon, tue, wed, thu, fri]
  - condition: state
    entity_id: input_boolean.vacation_mode
    state: "off"
action:
  - service: climate.set_temperature
    target: { entity_id: climate.kitchen }
    data: { temperature: 70 }
  - service: switch.turn_on
    target: { entity_id: switch.coffee_maker }
  - delay: "00:00:30"
  - service: light.turn_on
    target: { entity_id: light.kitchen }
    data: { brightness_pct: 35, kelvin: 2700 }
```

How to modify this

- Change *05:40:00* to 20 min before your actual alarm. Or trigger on your alarm entity if your phone exposes it.
- Remove the *weekday* condition to run 7 days a week.

- If your coffee maker needs a physical button after powering on, swap the switch for a smart button press or use a zwave scene controller.

UI-editor equivalent (for visual learners)

UI equivalent: Trigger "Time" at 05:40 → Conditions "Time" (weekdays) + "State" (vacation off) → three Action calls to climate, switch, and light.

Automation 4: Motion-Triggered Hallway at Night

A gentle 10% hallway light at 2200K (warm amber) when motion fires between 11pm and 6am. Stays on for 90 seconds after last motion, then fades out over 2 seconds. Won't wake you up. Won't stub your toe.
mode: restart means re-triggering motion extends the timer cleanly.

Prerequisites

Any motion sensor (Aqara, Hue, Zooz, etc.) exposed as a *binary_sensor*.

A dimmable, color-temperature-adjustable hallway light.

YAML (copy / paste)

```
alias: Motion Hallway – Night Dim
description: Dim hallway light comes on 10% between 11pm-6am when motion detected.
mode: restart
trigger:
  - platform: state
    entity_id: binary_sensor.hallway_motion
    to: "on"
condition:
  - condition: time
    after: "23:00:00"
    before: "06:00:00"
action:
  - service: light.turn_on
    target: { entity_id: light.hallway }
    data:
      brightness_pct: 10
      kelvin: 2200
  - wait_for_trigger:
      - platform: state
        entity_id: binary_sensor.hallway_motion
        to: "off"
        for: "00:01:30"
  - service: light.turn_off
    target: { entity_id: light.hallway }
    data: { transition: 2 }
```

How to modify this

- Drop the *kelvin* line if your light is white-only.
- Change the *00:01:30* duration to tune how long the light stays on after you stop moving.
- Add a condition checking an *input_boolean.guest_mode* to disable this when you have overnight guests in the hallway-adjacent room.

UI-editor equivalent (for visual learners)

UI equivalent: Trigger "State" on motion sensor to on → Condition "Time" 23:00-06:00 → Action light.turn_on at 10% → "Wait for trigger" (motion off, 90s) → light.turn_off with 2s transition.

Automation 5: Laundry Done Notification

A power-monitoring smart plug watches your washer. When draw drops below 5W for two minutes after being above 50W (the cycle was actually running), you get a phone push *and* a quick blue flash on the living-room light. This is the pattern every HA power user reuses for dishwasher, dryer, 3D printer, and EV charger.

Prerequisites

A smart plug with power monitoring (Kasa KP115, Zooz Zen15, Shelly Plug S).

HA Companion app installed on your phone (provides *notify.mobile_app_**).

Any color-capable light for the optional visual alert.

YAML (copy / paste)

```
alias: Laundry Done Notification
description: Notify when washer stops drawing power (cycle complete).
mode: single
trigger:
  - platform: numeric_state
    entity_id: sensor.washer_power
    below: 5
    for: "00:02:00"
condition:
  - condition: template
    value_template: "{{ trigger.from_state.state | float(0) > 50 }}"
action:
  - service: notify.mobile_app_my_phone
    data:
      title: "Laundry is done"
      message: "Washer cycle complete – move it before it gets funky."
  - service: light.turn_on
    target: { entity_id: light.living_room }
    data:
      flash: short
      rgb_color: [60, 180, 255]
```

How to modify this

- Tune the *below: 5* threshold to match your washer's true off-state (some draw 2W at rest).
- Drop the *flash* action if you just want the silent phone push.
- Duplicate the whole automation for your dryer, dishwasher, or 3D printer — swap the entity IDs.

UI-editor equivalent (for visual learners)

UI equivalent: Trigger "Numeric state" (washer_power below 5 for 2min) → Condition "Template" checking previous state was >50W → Actions: mobile push + light flash.

Want 47 more automations (and the install walkthrough)?

These five are the warm-up. The full book walks you from HA OS install on a Raspberry Pi or old PC, through Zigbee2MQTT, Node-RED, Blueprints, templating, voice assistants, and the 47 automation patterns that cover 95% of real-world smart homes.

HA Automation Tracker — on Etsy

A printable + digital tracker for planning, testing, and documenting your automations before they drift. Pre-filled with the 5 in this PDF so you can start marking them green.

Grab it here:

The Full Book — Home Assistant Smart Home for Beginners

Digital Basics Press. Kindle + Kindle Unlimited. Covers Raspberry Pi install, Zigbee2MQTT, voice pipelines, Blueprints, templating, Node-RED, and the complete 47-automation cookbook.

What happens next

You got this PDF because you joined the Skill Mill list. The next three emails cover: Zigbee2MQTT setup (the single biggest reliability upgrade), Voice Assistant options in 2026 (local-first), and a Blueprint pack of the above 5 automations. After that, roughly one email a week.

- Reply to any email — a real person reads them. Bug reports on the YAML especially welcome.
- Unsubscribe link is at the bottom of every email. No guilt.
- Tested on Home Assistant 2026.x. If a future version breaks a snippet, we'll publish an updated PDF.

Troubleshooting the YAML

Paste into Developer Tools → YAML Editor — it will syntax-check inline.

If Home Assistant says "extra keys not allowed" — you pasted an extra indent. Unindent one level.

If an entity isn't found — Settings → Devices & Services → search the friendly name → copy the true `entity_id`.

Every automation uses *mode: single* or *restart* — never *parallel* unless you know why.